



NATIONAL MUSEUM, DELHI

A LIVING SHOWCASE

It has a premier address—south of Rajpath, in the heart of Lutyen's Delhi. Add to that a collection of over two lakh works of art and sculpture of Indian and foreign origin in an impressive three-storey building and it's easy to see why the National Museum is the best in the country. Everyday, an average of 700 visitors climb its imposing flight of stairs and walk down a passageway lined with stone sculptures for a glimpse of the 5,000-year-old history, dating back to 3rd century B.C.. From the bronze dancing girl of Mohenjo-Daro and a 5th century Buddha head from the Gupta period to gold coins from the Tughlaq dynasty, it's on the must-visit list. "It's the best place to get a sense of the wealth and cultural heritage of the country," says R.S.S. Chauhan, director, exhibitions, at the National Museum. The blueprint for the museum was first

drawn up in 1946 by the Gwyer Committee. Construction started in 1955, and five years later, in June 1960, the museum opened formally with five galleries and tickets that costed four annas. "The museum has now grown to house 30 galleries, including Central Asian antiquities with more than 11,000 objects and pre-Columbian art dating to 1200 B.C.," says Chauhan. Audio tours in five languages, covering 50 exhibits, have also made the experience richer for visitors. But despite an art library, a 240-seater auditorium to screen educational films and special lectures, the National Museum is handicapped by a shortage of staff and infrastructural crunch. But despite roadblocks, the museum continues to represent creative traditions and a history that spans decades of India's past.

by Deepika Khatri

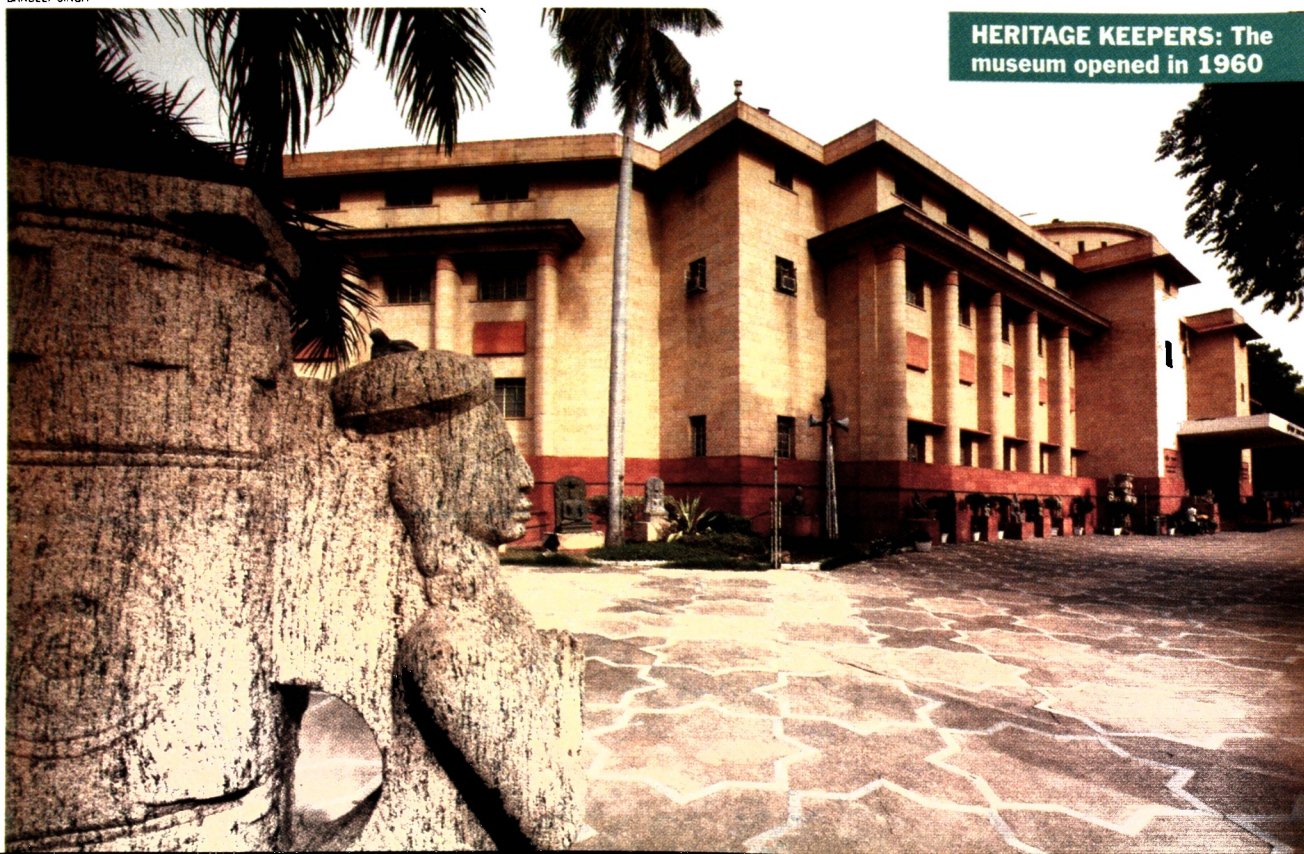
"It is the best place to get a sense of the wealth and cultural heritage of the country."

**R.S.S. CHAUHAN, DIRECTOR, EXHIBITIONS,
NATIONAL MUSEUM**

2 lakh

is the total number of art works in the museum, of which only 10 per cent are on display. The art library, which has a capacity to store around 60,000 volumes, currently houses only 55,000 volumes.

BANDEEP SINGH



**HERITAGE KEEPERS: The
museum opened in 1960**